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Glossary

13 Glossary

This Glossary contains terms that are technical from an exegetical or linguistic viewpoint. Other terms not defined here may be found in a Bible dictionary.

ABSTRACT NOUN is one that refers to a quality or characteristic, such as “beauty” or “darkness.”

ADJECTIVE is a word that limits, describes, or qualifies a noun. In English “red,” “tall,” “beautiful,” and “important” are adjectives

AGENT is one who does the action in a sentence or clause, regardless of whether the grammatical construction is active or passive. In “John hit Bill” (active) and “Bill was hit by John” (passive), the agent in both cases is “John.”

ALLUSION is an indirect or general reference to information or to a text that is already well known. For example, when the Preacher in Ecclesiastes says “and the dust returns to the earth” (ECC 12:7), this appears to be an allusion to a passage in Genesis (GEN 3:19).

AMBIGUITY refers to words or sentences that have more than one possible meaning in a given context. For example, in the sentence “Mike said that if Joe comes, he will speak to the president,” “he” could refer to Mike or to Joe. Thus this sentence is AMBIGUOUS. Often what is ambiguous in written form is not ambiguous when actually spoken, since intonation and other features of speech help to make the meaning clear. In written discourse, context also helps to indicate which meaning is intended by the author.

ANACHRONISM (ANACHRONISTIC) is an expression that is incorrectly used because it is historically or chronologically misplaced. For example, to refer to Jonah buying a ticket for his sea voyage would be an anachronism because it introduces a modern custom into an ancient setting.

The **APOCRYPHA** is a group of books included in the Greek SEPTUAGINT and the Old Testament of the Latin VULGATE but not in the PROTOCANON of the Hebrew canon. See also DEUTEROCANON.

APPOSITION is the placing of two expressions together so that they both refer to the same object, event, or concept; for example, “my friend, Mr. Smith.”

ARAMAIC is a SEMITIC language that was widely used in Southwest Asia in lands east of the Mediterranean Sea before and during the time of Christ. It is related to HEBREW and in many contexts had replaced Hebrew in use among the Jewish people in the land of Israel at the time of the New Testament.

ARCHAEOLOGY (ARCHAEOLOGICAL EVIDENCE) refers to the study of materials from the past that are dug up or that are found and interpreted to explain life in earlier times. This evidence may lend support to written documents or may give us information to help us understand the text as well as the people of the days when the text was written.

ARTICLE is a grammatical class of words, often obligatory, which indicate whether the word to which it is connected is definite or indefinite. In English the DEFINITE ARTICLE is “the,” and the indefinite article is “a” or “an.”

ASSONANCE is the repetition of the same or similar vowels in two or more words in close succession; for example, “A good look at the wool” and “Stick the pin in his fingertip.”

BORROWING is the process of using a foreign word in another language. For example, “matador” is a Spanish word that has been BORROWED by English speakers for “bullfighter.”

CLASSIFIER is a term used with another term (often a proper noun) to indicate to what category the latter belongs. “Town” may serve as a classifier in the phrase “town of Bethlehem,” and “river” as a classifier in “river Jordan.”

CLAUSE is a grammatical construction, normally consisting of a subject and a predicate.

COLLECTIVE describes a group of things (or persons) considered as a whole, such as “rice” or “crowd.” In English a collective noun is considered to be singular or plural, more or less on the basis of traditional usage; for example, “The crowd is [The people are] becoming angry.”

COMMON-LANGUAGE TRANSLATION uses language that is widely understood and accepted by most speakers. In such a translation, substandard speech, dialect peculiarities, and highly literary or technical terms are avoided.

COMPONENTS are the parts or elements that go together to form the whole of an object. For example, the components of bread are flour, salt, shortening, yeast, and water. The components of the meaning of a term are the elements of meaning that it contains. For example, some of the components of "boy" are "human," "male," and "immature."

CONNOTE means to suggest or imply a meaning that is not explicit in the term used. See EXPLICIT.

CONSONANTS are speech sounds that are produced by blocking or restricting the passage of air as it comes from the lungs through the mouth. The written letters representing those sounds are also called consonants; for example, "b," "d," "f," "k," or "m" in English. Consonants were originally the only spoken sounds written in the Hebrew alphabet. Marks for VOWELS were added later above or below the consonants. See also VOWELS.

CONTEXT is that which precedes and/or follows any part of a discourse. For example, the context of a word or phrase in Scripture would be the words and phrases associated with it in the sentence, paragraph, section, and even the entire book in which it occurs. The context of a term often affects its meaning, so that a word does not mean exactly the same thing in one context that it does in another.

CULTURAL EQUIVALENT is a kind of translation in which certain details from the culture of the source language are changed because they have no meaning or may even carry a wrong meaning for speakers of the receptor language. Cultural equivalent translation should be used only when absolutely necessary for conveying the intended meaning, and it may be important to add an explanatory note. See CULTURE.

CULTURE (CULTURAL) is the combination of beliefs, values, social institutions, customs, and material objects (such as tools or ornaments) of any group of people. A culture is passed on from one generation to another but undergoes development or gradual change.

DEFINITE ARTICLE. See ARTICLE.

DESCRIPTIVE is said of a word or phrase that characterizes or describes another term.

DEUTEROCANON (DEUTEROCANONICAL) is another term for what is referred to by some as the APOCRYPHA. These are writings that are included in the Greek SEPTUAGINT and the Old Testament of the Latin VULGATE but not in the PROTOCANON of the Hebrew canon.

DIMINUTIVE is a word form indicating primarily smallness of size, but also familiarity, endearment, or (in some cases) contempt.

DYNAMIC EQUIVALENT TRANSLATION refers to a translation that tries to give the intended meaning of the source text in a natural and meaningful way so that it produces a response in today's reader that is essentially equivalent to that of the original reader. LITERAL translations pay more attention to reproducing the forms found in the source text. For example, RSV follows the Hebrew wording of PSA 104:29 and says: "they die and return to their dust." CEV tries to give a dynamic equivalent translation: "they die and rot.".

ELLIPSIS refers to words or phrases normally omitted in a discourse when the sense is perfectly clear without them. In the following sentence, the words within brackets are elliptical: "If [it is] necessary [for me to do so], I will wait up all night." What is elliptical in one language may need to be expressed in another.

EMENDATION (EMEND) is a correction of a text. It is usually a change made by a scholar through a process of critical editing and not based directly on manuscript evidence.

EMPHASIS is the relative importance given to an element in a discourse. Emphasis is conveyed by many different devices, depending on the language; for example, positioning of words, emphatic particles, intensifiers, or ideophones. In "Oh, that you had heeded my commandments!" (ISA 48:18, NKJV), the particle "Oh" marks this statement as emphatic.

EQUIVALENCE (EQUIVALENT) is a very close similarity in meaning or in form. See DYNAMIC EQUIVALENT TRANSLATION and FORMAL TRANSLATION.

ETYMOLOGY is the study of the derivation or history of words. While this can be a helpful study in many ways, it is much more important to know how a word is understood by its users in the actual context of the source language.

EUPHEMISM is a mild or indirect term used in the place of another term which is felt to be impolite, distasteful, or vulgar; for example, "to pass away" is a euphemism for "to die."

EXAGGERATION is stating more than the speaker or writer knows to be true. Exaggeration may be used to express humor, IRONY, or sarcasm, or to make a particular point. For example, "Everyone is doing it" can mean "Many people are doing it" (implying "and I want to do it, too"). See also HYPERBOLE.

EXPANDED TRANSLATION, or EXPANSION, involves translating a single word or short phrase with a longer one in order to introduce information that will give the reader an understanding that is equivalent functionally to that of the original audience.

EXPLICIT refers to meaning that is expressed overtly in the words of a discourse. This is in contrast to IMPLICIT information.

FIGURE, FIGURE OF SPEECH, or FIGURATIVE EXPRESSION involves the use of words in other than their LITERAL or ordinary sense in order to bring out some aspect of meaning by comparison or association. For example, when the psalmist says "my cup overflows," he is not saying his cup is too full. He is rather using a figure of speech to say that he is as content as someone who has been served a generous portion. METAPHORS and SIMILES are common figures of speech.

FOCUS is the center of attention in a discourse. It may be marked in a special way such as by word order, a special particle, or repetition.

FORMAL TRANSLATION is a type of translation in which many features of the source text, especially the form of the discourse, have been literally reproduced in the translation. This approach often results in an unnatural style in the receptor language, or sometimes in the lack of any meaning at all. See LITERAL.

FUNCTIONAL EQUIVALENT is a type of translation that attempts to convey the same set of communicative functions as that of the original source text. Some important functions of communication are to convey information, to express or evoke emotions, to promote changes in thinking or behavior, or to maintain good interpersonal relations. See also DYNAMIC EQUIVALENT TRANSLATION, which has a similar meaning.

GENERAL, or GENERIC, refers to a general class or kind of object. It contrasts with PARTICULAR and SPECIFIC. For example, the word "food" is a generic term, while "fruit" is more specific. However, the word "fruit" is a generic term for the more specific word "orange."

GENITIVE refers to a grammatical set of forms occurring in many languages, used primarily to indicate that a noun is the modifier of another noun. The genitive often indicates possession, but it may also indicate measure, origin, characteristic, separation, or source; for example, "people of God," "man of peace," "pound of flour," "child's toy," or "Garden of Eden."

GLOSSARY is a list, usually included at the back of a book, explaining or defining unusual words or expressions used in the text.

GREEK is the language in which the New Testament was written. It belongs to the Indo-European family of languages and was spoken in the area that is today called Greece. By the time of Christ, Greek was used by many of the people living in the eastern part of the Roman empire, so that early Christians could speak and write to one another in Greek, even though they were born in different countries. By that time the entire Hebrew Old Testament had been translated into Greek, a version referred to as the SEPTUAGINT.

HEBREW is the language in which most of the Old Testament was written. It belongs to the SEMITIC family of languages. By the time of Christ many Jewish people no longer used Hebrew as their common language, but spoke ARAMAIC (a language related to Hebrew) or GREEK.

HYPERBOLE is a figure of speech that makes use of EXAGGERATION. A deliberate overstatement is made to create a special effect. "He cries night and day" is an example of hyperbole. The statement does not mean that the person cries every moment of the night and day, but that he cries a great deal.

IDIOM, or IDIOMATIC EXPRESSION, is a combination of terms whose meanings cannot be understood by adding up the meanings of the parts. "To hang one's head" is an English idiom. "A drop in the bucket" is an idiom coming from Hebrew (ISA 40:15). Idiomatic expressions almost always lose their meaning or convey a wrong meaning when translated literally from one language to another.

IMMEDIATE CONTEXT refers to the words that immediately precede or follow a discourse or segment of discourse, and which often help one to interpret the meaning of the whole section. For example, PSA 1:2 is a passage in the immediate context of PSA 1:1 and helps to interpret it. See also CONTEXT.

IMPERATIVE refers to forms of a verb that indicate commands or requests. In PSA 34:11 there are two imperative forms: "Come, you children, listen to me." Imperatives are often used together with vocative expressions ("you children"). In some languages imperatives occur only in the second person; but in others imperatives also occur in the first and third persons. These are usually expressed in English by the use of "must" or "let"; for example, "They must work harder!" or "Let us go to the house of the LORD."

IMPLICIT, or IMPLIED refers to information which is conveyed by a text, but which is not expressed in words. The speaker assumes that the hearer understands the meaning. Often the meaning is clear from the CONTEXT. For example, when Hannah says in 1SA 2:6 "He brings down to Sheol and raises up," the implied or implicit meaning is "raises up to life." See EXPLICIT.

INTERPRETATION is the process of determining the meaning of a text (or the result of this process), normally in terms of "who said what to whom under what circumstances and with what intent." A correct interpretation is indispensable before a passage can be translated correctly.

IRONY occurs when a person says one thing but means another, often for the purpose of criticism, rebuke, or instruction. When Job says to his friend, "How you have helped him who has no power!" (JOB 26:2), he is using irony. He means "You have not helped at all!"

LITERAL means the ordinary or primary meaning of a term or expression, in contrast with a FIGURATIVE meaning. A LITERAL TRANSLATION is one that is very close to the forms and word order of the source language; such a translation is frequently unnatural or awkward in the RECEPTOR LANGUAGE.

LITURGICAL refers to liturgy, or public worship, including songs, prayers, responses, and so forth. Liturgical language is often traditional or old-fashioned.

LOAN WORD is a foreign word that is used in another language. See BORROWING.

MANUSCRIPTS are books, documents, or letters written or copied by hand. Thousands of manuscript copies of various Old and New Testament books still exist, but none of the original manuscripts.

MARGINAL NOTES are notes that normally occur on the same page as the text and provide purely objective, factual information of the following types: alternative readings (different forms of the source-language text), alternative renderings (different ways of rendering the source-language text), historical data, and cultural details, all of which may be necessary for a satisfactory understanding of the text.

METAPHOR is likening one object, event, or state (the "topic") to another (the "image") to which it is not directly or closely related in meaning. For example, when a person says "I am a worm," he is describing his state as being lowly, miserable, or of no value. Biblical metaphors are often difficult to understand because the basis for the comparison is not always stated, as in the line "The LORD is my rock" (PSA 18:2). At other times either the image or the basis of comparison is unfamiliar or used differently in the receptor language. For example, when the psalmist says "He remembers that we are dust" (PSA 103:14), he is not referring to the dirt or dust on our bodies. Metaphors are the most commonly used figures of speech and are often so subtle that a speaker or writer is not conscious of the fact that he or she is using figurative language. See SIMILE.

METONYM is a figure of speech in which a part of an object is used to indicate the entire object (for example, "one hundred head" means "one hundred cows"), or in which an object stands for another object to which it is related (for example, "the crown" can refer to the king or even the entire royal government).

MODIFIER is a grammatical term referring to a word or a phrase that is used to modify or affect the meaning of another part of the sentence, such as an adjective modifying a noun or an adverb modifying a verb.

NONFIGURATIVE involves the use of words in their literal or ordinary sense. See FIGURE, FIGURE OF SPEECH, FIGURATIVE EXPRESSION.

NOUN is a word that names a person, place, thing, quality, action or idea.

PARABLE is a short story designed to illustrate or teach some truth, religious principle, or moral lesson. Jesus often used parables to illustrate truths concerning the kingdom of God (for example, the parable of the mustard seed in MRK 4:30; MRK 4:31; MRK 4:32).

PARALLEL, (PARALLELISM) generally refers to some similarity in the content and/or form of two parts of a construction; for example, "Hear this, all peoples! Give ear, all inhabitants of the world." The structures that correspond to each other in the two statements are said to be parallel. PARALLEL PASSAGES are two or more portions of biblical text that resemble each other, often by using a series of words that are identical. For example, the Lord's Prayer as recorded in MAT 6:9; MAT 6:10; MAT 6:11; MAT 6:12; MAT 6:13 has as its parallel LUK 11:2; LUK 11:3; LUK 11:4.

PARTICULAR is the opposite of GENERAL. See GENERIC.

PASSAGE is the text of Scripture in a specific location. It is usually thought of as comprising more than one verse, but it can be a single verse or part of a verse.

PEJORATIVE means having a disparaging effect or force. For example, the suffix "-ish" in "childish" is pejorative.

PENTATEUCH refers to the first five books of the Bible, sometimes called "the Torah," "the Law," or "the Books of Moses."

PHRASE is a dependent grammatical construction of two or more words, but less than a complete clause or a sentence. A phrase is usually given a name according to its function in a sentence, such as that of a noun phrase, VERB PHRASE, or prepositional phrase. For example, "the boy in front" is a noun phrase, "in front of the house" is a prepositional phrase, and "carried a heavy load" is a verb phrase.

PLURAL refers to the form of a word that indicates more than one. See SINGULAR.

POETRY refers to a literary genre that differs from everyday speech and from PROSE because of its rhythmic and heightened style. Poets use special language to create a mood or image to be shared with the hearer or reader. Each language has special stylistic devices such as figurative language, word order variation, wordplay, repetition or rhyming that are especially frequent in poetry (compare JDG 4:0 and JDG 5:0). The boundary between beautiful, artistic prose and poetry is sometimes difficult to determine, but speakers of a language can usually distinguish poetry from ordinary speech. Poetry is usually written or spoken in measured or balanced lines, while prose is not.

PROTOCANON includes the Hebrew books of the Old Testament and all of the New Testament. These books are commonly accepted as CANONICAL by both Protestants and Roman Catholics.

PROVERB is a short saying familiar to most members of a community. It is expressed in an easily remembered form and makes some observation about human life or the world.

QUALIFIER (QUALIFY) is a term that limits the meaning of another term. For example, in "old man," the term "old" qualifies the term "man."

READ (READING) refers to the wording of a particular manuscript for a passage. Two manuscripts may have different wordings in the same passage, or two versions may have two different meanings. For example, in 1SA 1:24 the Hebrew text says "three bulls," but the Greek and Syriac versions say "a three-year-old bull." These are different readings. See also TEXT.

RECEPTOR is the person(s) receiving a message. The RECEPTOR LANGUAGE is the language into which a translation is made. For example, in a translation from Hebrew into German, Hebrew is the source language and German is the receptor language.

RENDER means to translate or express in a language different from the original.

RENDERING is the manner in which a specific passage is translated from one language to another.

RESTRUCTURE is to rearrange the various components of a sentence or other unit of discourse in the translation process.

RHETORICAL refers to forms of speech that are employed to highlight or make more attractive some aspect of a discourse. A rhetorical question, for example, is not a request for information but is usually a way of making an emphatic statement.

ROOT refers to the smallest element of a word, from which other words may be derived. For example, "friend" is the root of "friendliness." In Hebrew most roots are made up of three consonants, and many words are formed on the basis of this root. For example, the root b-r-k is the basis for the noun "blessing," the adjective "blessed," and the verb "to bless."

SEMANTIC refers to meaning. Semantics is the study of the meaning of any element of discourse, oral or written.

SEMITIC refers to a family of languages that includes HEBREW, ARAMAIC, and Arabic.

SENTENCE is a grammatical construction composed of one or more clauses and capable of standing alone.

SEPTUAGINT is a translation of the Hebrew Old Testament into Greek, begun some two hundred years before Christ. It is often abbreviated as LXX.

SIMILE (pronounced SIM-i-lee) is a FIGURE OF SPEECH that describes one event or object (the "topic") by comparing it to another event or object (the "image"). Similes always use words of comparison such as "like" or "as." "Your lips [the topic] are like a scarlet thread [the image]" is a simile from SNG 4:3. Similes differ from METAPHORS in that metaphors do not mark the image with words that indicate comparison. See METAPHOR.

SINGULAR refers to the form of a word that indicates one thing or person, in contrast to PLURAL, which indicates more than one.

SPECIFIC refers to the opposite of GENERAL and GENERIC. See GENERIC.

STRUCTURE is the systematic arrangement of the elements of language, including the ways in which words combine into phrases, phrases into clauses, clauses into sentences, and sentences into larger units of discourse. This process can be compared to constructing a building so structures are often spoken of as constructions.

SYMBOL (SYMBOLIC) is a form, whether linguistic or nonlinguistic, which is arbitrarily and conventionally associated with a particular meaning. For example, the word "cross" is a linguistic symbol, referring to a particular object. Similarly, within the Christian tradition, the cross as an object is a symbol for the death of Jesus.

SYNONYMOUS refers to words that are different in form but similar in meaning, such as "boy" and "lad."

TARGUM is an Aramaic translation or paraphrase of a section of the ancient Hebrew Scriptures.

TEXT (TEXTUAL) refers to the various Biblical manuscripts. A textual READING is the form in which words occur in a particular manuscript (or group of manuscripts), especially where it differs from others. Textual evidence is any evidence from manuscripts that may support a particular reading. TEXTUAL PROBLEMS arise when manuscripts contain different readings.

TEXTUAL VARIATIONS are readings of the same passage that differ in one or more details. An EMENDATION is a scholar's reconstruction of what the ancient text may have been, even though no manuscript exists today to support that reconstruction. See also MANUSCRIPTS.

TRANSLATION is the transfer of a message in a source-language text into another language, the RECEPTOR LANGUAGE. A good translation aims at giving the closest natural equivalent in the receptor language in terms of meaning (content and function) and, if possible, also form (style and structure).

TRANSLITERATE (TRANSLITERATION) is to represent in the RECEPTOR LANGUAGE the approximate sounds or letters of words occurring in the source language. Transliterating is different from TRANSLATING. For example, "Amen" in Hebrew may be transliterated in one language as "amin," or it may be translated as "So be it."

VERBS are a grammatical class of words that express existence, action, state, or occurrence, such as "be," "run," "become," or "think." In some languages ideas expressed by ADJECTIVES in English may be better expressed by verbs; for example, "to be hot" or "to be angry."

VERSIONS are different translations of the same original document. Among ancient versions of the Bible are the Greek Septuagint, the Syriac, and the Ethiopic. RSV and GNT are modern versions in English.

VOWELS are speech sounds of the vocal cords, produced by unobstructed air passing from the lungs though the mouth. The written letters representing those sounds are also called vowels; for example, “a,” “i,” or “u,” which are the most common vowels found in the world’s languages. In Hebrew vowels were originally not written, but they were added later as small marks (called VOWEL POINTS) written under or above the CONSONANTS. See also CONSONANTS.

The VULGATE is the Latin version of the Bible translated and/or edited originally by Saint Jerome near the end of the fourth century A.D. It has been traditionally the official version of the Roman Catholic Church.